

Episode 165: Side Story: About Names

My goodness. Sorry for taking such a long break from publication.

Currently participating in a new programmes starting broadcast in July. First TV series in almost a year since *The Tatami Galaxy*. Just over a month until broadcast. Entering the climax of programmes startup - quite difficult in various ways. With all this, I couldn't move freely and kept missing manuscript deadlines. Everyone, I'm sorry.

Now, this new TV series - I'm handling Episode 1 colour direction as usual, but I'm scheduled to participate in colour direction for quite a number of episodes this series. This 2-cour, planned 24-episode series - this is my focus this year. Please look forward to it.

Eh? The title? Official staff announcements haven't been made yet... (sweat). The workplace is dizzyingly busy, but working with this director for the first time in quite a while is quite enjoyable with continuous surprises and laughter.

...So, I've returned after 3 weeks?

Anyway.

The Anime Style talk event "Yamauchi Shigeyasu's World Part 1" was recently held with great success. I also appeared as someone who knows Director Yamauchi, talking about old stories (already a quarter century ago (laugh)) and various things.

Well, I didn't talk about this at the event, but about Director Yamauchi's and my names.

Many of you probably know, but I actually worked under names other than my real name. The credit "Kokuon Kunio" - some of you have probably seen it somewhere.

Starting with *Revolutionary Girl Utena*, through *Strange Dawn*, *Kaleido Star*, theatrical *Fist of the North Star* trilogy, etc.

Well, since the statute of limitations has passed (has it?), I'll talk about it - these works were so-called "other company work" during my time at Toei. So they were credited with concealed characters, or pen names, or false names, aliases. That was Kokuon Kunio.

Working on other company productions while doing Toei Animation work, but being involved with productions meant not being half-hearted, not causing trouble for other staff - I resolved this and approached productions with the stance of giving 100% to Toei work and equally 100% to other company productions. However, it couldn't be like Toei work where I'd handle everything (colour design & colour direction inspection), so participation was like character colour design only, or colour design only - such forms of full participation.

Those in the industry understand well that Toei Animation and other productions have greatly different production methods and workplace systems. Toei is somewhat of a black box. Since almost all parts are made with basically in-house staff (including TAP), Toei's style has formed in production. That has good aspects, but I was interested in other productions' styles, and there were many good aspects not found at Toei. So I wanted to experience that and make it mine, and reflect that experience even slightly into Toei's system. With such personal convictions, I participated whenever asked.

Initially when first using this name for *Utena*, I hadn't thought much about the future, but thankfully I received various work offers afterward. Among those, from around participating in *Kaleido Star*, I began thinking "ah, I'd like to make this 'Kokuon Kunio' into a brand." "Tsujita Kunio" at Toei, and "Kokuon Kunio" elsewhere. Having encountered works with different tastes from Toei works, I arbitrarily thought "I'd like to develop this into a brand."

And then *Casshern Sins*. This work was also initially discussed with the production producer as Kokuon Kunio credit, but when the opening was finally completed and credit discussions began, Director Yamauchi said this:

"When putting names in the opening, if it's not a real name, it seems not serious and is disrespectful to all other staff."

This single statement was tremendously shocking to me. Director Yamauchi always sharply strikes the essence of matters directly with few words like this. I thought I was working on productions with sincerity and full effort, working hard without causing much trouble, but people seeing this credit might not think so... Honestly, I hadn't considered such things at all.

Having names credited in productions means, for better or worse, "I'm responsible for this part." Moreover, when it's opening credits, this becomes a responsibility issue for the entire production. Not crediting with real names there certainly could seem like escaping that responsibility.

For *Casshern Sins*, I decided to be credited with my real name. And simultaneously, I decided to work with only my own name going forward and quit Toei Animation, where I'd been long cared for, to become freelance.

It's been three years now, but I think that decision was correct. Being able to continue without wavering like this is thanks to what Yamauchi-san said that time - I'm grateful. Works marking turning points for me are always Director Yamauchi's works.